

Ducker

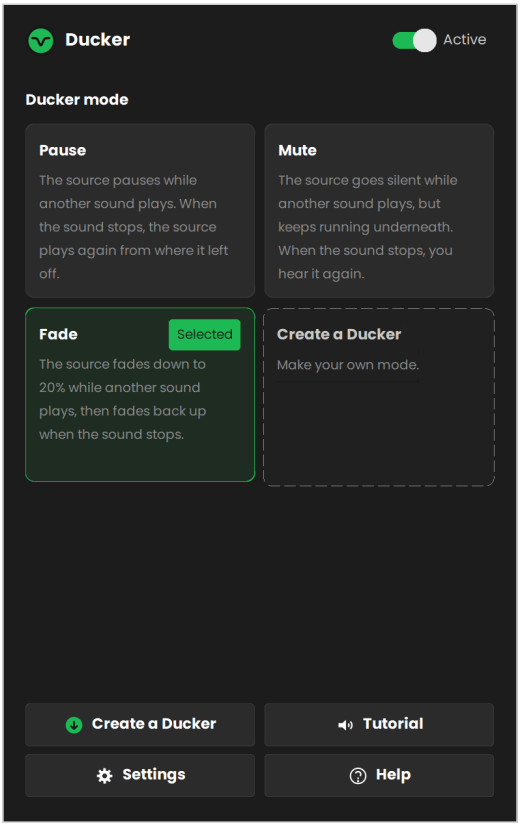
The guide

What Ducker does, how to set it up, and what every button and setting is for. Written for someone who has never used it.

What Ducker is

Ducker is a small Windows app that turns your music down when something else on your PC makes a sound, and turns it back up when that sound stops. It sits by the clock and listens. You do not need to touch it once it is set up.

Say you are listening to Spotify and you open a YouTube video. The moment the video makes a sound, Spotify drops to 20% volume. When the video ends, Spotify fades back to full. That dip is called a **duck**, which is where the name comes from.



The front page. Ducker is on, and Fade is the chosen mode.

Three words to know

Source is what you are listening to. Usually music, but it can be a podcast, a film or a game. The source is what Ducker turns down.

Sound is any other noise on your PC. A video, a call, a game, a notification. Ducker hears it and keeps it clear. A sound is what makes the source duck.

Duck is the dip itself. The source gets quieter, pauses or goes silent while a sound plays, then comes back when the sound stops.

Everything else in the app is just a way of choosing what counts as a source, what counts as a sound, and what the duck does.

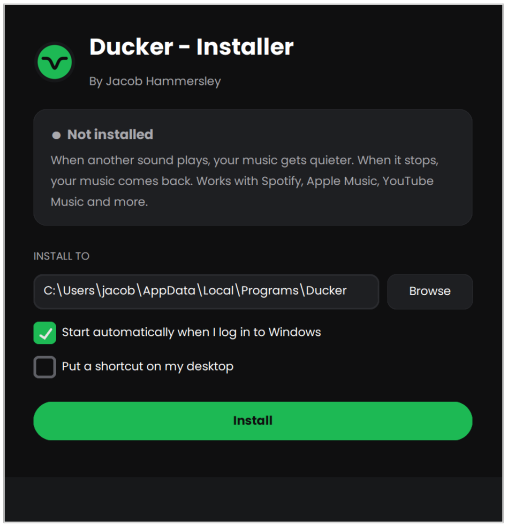
The whole app in one paragraph

Pick a **Ducker mode** on the front page. Add the apps you listen to as **Sources** in Settings. Leave the Active switch on. That is it. Ducker does the rest in the background, and the Tutorial shows the duck happening with two recordings if you want to hear it before you trust it.

Installing Ducker

Ducker comes as one file, **Ducker - Installer.exe**. Open it and you see the window on the right.

- Leave the install folder as it is unless you have a reason to change it.
- Keep **Start automatically when I log in to Windows** ticked. Ducker is only useful if it is running, and it uses almost nothing while it waits.
- Tick **Put a shortcut on my desktop** if you want one. The Start Menu gets one either way.
- Press **Install**. It takes a few seconds, then Ducker opens and the installer closes itself.



The installer.

If Windows shows a blue warning

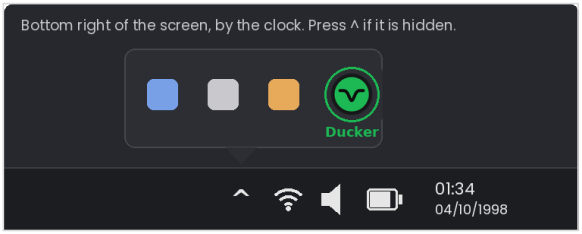
Windows SmartScreen warns about any new program it has not seen many times before. If you see "Windows protected your PC", click **More info**, then **Run anyway**. Ducker does not connect to the internet and does not change anything outside its own folder.

What gets installed

The installer puts two things in the Start Menu, in a folder called Ducker. **Ducker** is the app. **Ducker - Uninstall** removes it again. Ducker also appears in Windows Settings under Installed apps, like any other program.

Where Ducker lives once it is running

Ducker lives in the system tray, the row of small icons by the clock at the bottom right of the screen. Closing or minimising the window does not quit Ducker. It just tucks it away in the tray, still listening.



Click the green icon to open the window again. Right-click it for a menu where you can switch modes, open Settings, put the music back to full volume or quit.

If you cannot see the icon, press the small **^** arrow by the clock to show the hidden ones.

The program lives in **AppData \ Local \ Programs \ Ducker** in your user folder. Its settings and its log live in **AppData \ Roaming \ Ducker**. Nothing is written anywhere else.

The front page

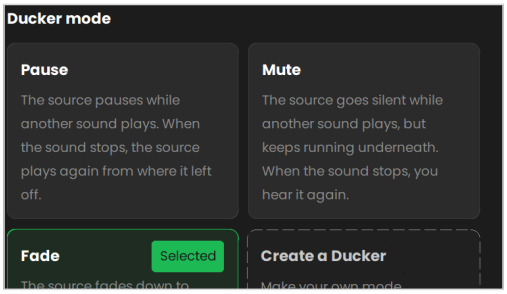
This is what you see when Ducker opens. Everything you need day to day is here.

The Active switch



The switch at the top right turns Ducker on and off. When it is off, nothing is ducked and everything plays as normal. Ducker stays running in the tray so you can switch it back on with one click. Your settings are kept either way.

Ducker mode



The four tiles decide what the duck does. Click one and it is chosen straight away. The green **Selected** badge shows which one is in use, and the choice is saved for next time.

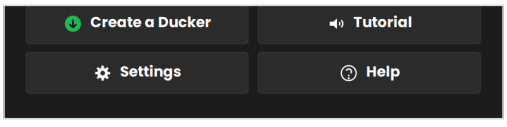
Pause stops the source completely while a sound plays. When the sound stops, the source carries on from where it left off. Good for podcasts and audiobooks, where you do not want to miss anything.

Mute makes the source silent but keeps it running underneath. When the sound stops you hear it again, wherever it has got to. Good for radio or long playlists.

Fade turns the source down to 20% while a sound plays, then fades it back up over a second and a half. This is the default and the one most people want for music.

Create a Ducker opens a window where you make a mode of your own, with your own volume, speeds and sensitivity. See the next page.

The four buttons



Create a Ducker makes a new mode of your own.

Tutorial opens a guided walk-through with two recordings, so you can hear a duck happen before you rely on it. It takes about a minute.

Settings is where you tell Ducker which apps are sources, which sounds to ignore, and whether your microphone should count.

Help answers the questions people ask most, in plain words. Every answer is also in this guide.

The window can be resized. Pressing Escape on the front page sends Ducker to the tray, and on any other page it takes you back to the front page.

Create a Ducker

The three built-in modes cover most people. If you want something different, say a gentler dip to 50% or a slower fade, make your own. Press **Create a Ducker** on the front page and this window opens.

Name

Call it anything. If you leave it blank it is called "My first Ducker", then "Ducker 2" and so on.

Effect

Pause, Mute or Fade, the same three behaviours as the front page. The options below change depending on which one you pick.

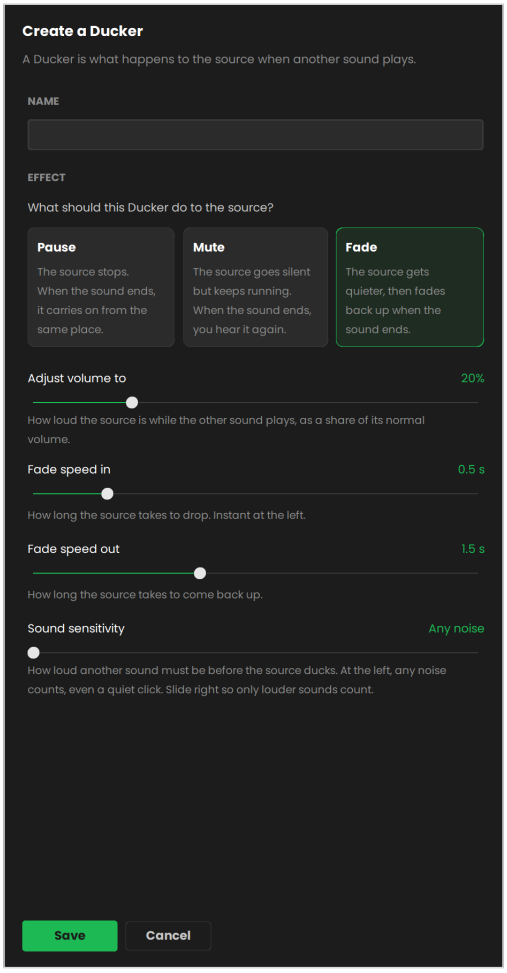
The Fade options

Adjust volume to is how loud the source is while a sound plays, as a share of its normal volume. 20% is a quiet background. 0% is silence.

Fade speed in is how long the source takes to drop. Instant at the left, up to three seconds.

Fade speed out is how long the source takes to come back up once the sound has stopped.

Sound sensitivity is how loud another sound must be before the source ducks. At the far left it says **Any noise**, which means even a quiet click counts. Slide right and it shows a number, for example **Over 4%**, meaning a sound has to reach that level before anything happens. Move it right if small noises keep ducking your music.



Create a Ducker with Fade chosen.

The Pause and Mute option

Delay before the source comes back is how long Ducker waits after a sound stops before the source resumes. A short delay stops the music jumping back in during a brief pause in a video. **No delay** at the far left means it comes back at once.

Saving

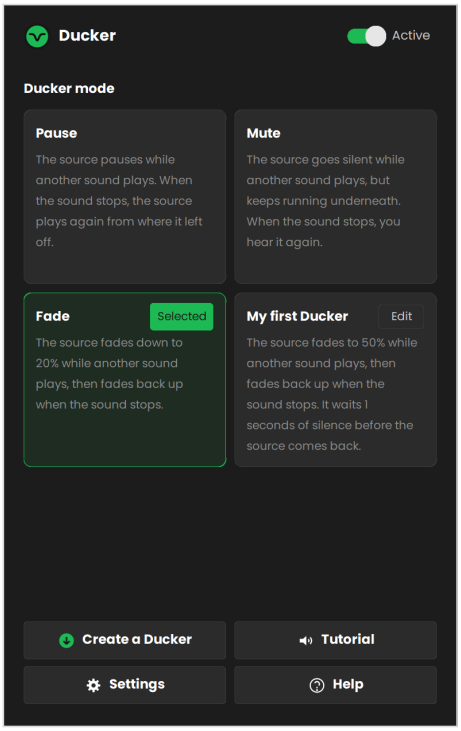
Press **Save** and the new mode appears on the front page as a tile, already selected. **Cancel** throws it away.

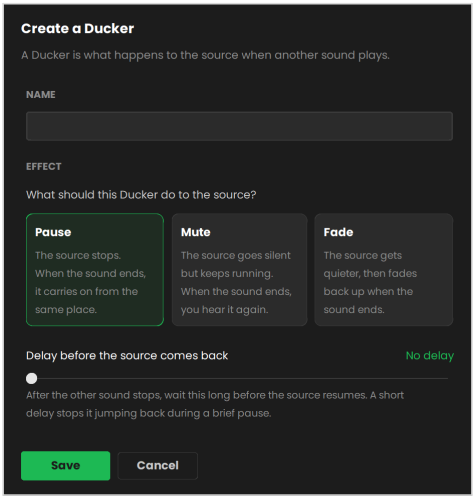
Changing or deleting a mode you made

Your own modes sit on the front page next to the built-in three, each with an **Edit** button. Edit opens the same window with your values filled in.

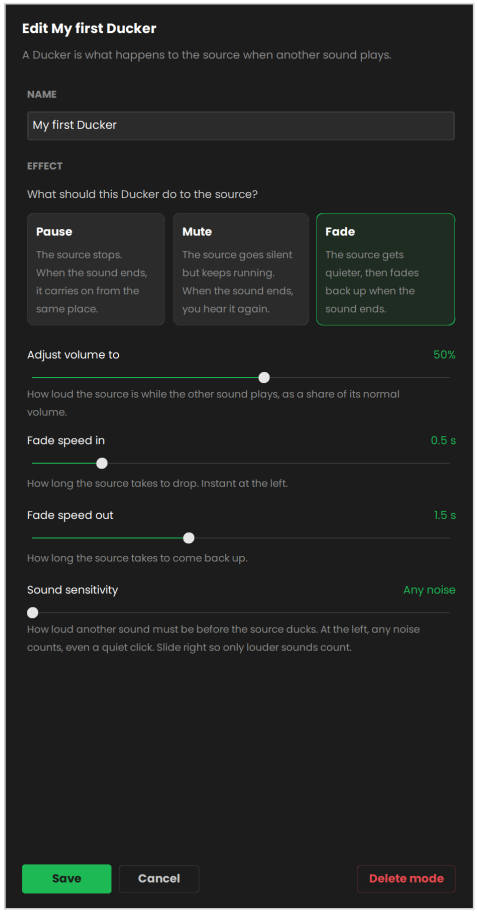
In the edit window there is a red **Delete mode** button on the right of Save and Cancel. Deleting a mode that is currently selected puts Ducker back on Fade.

You can make as many modes as you like. They are saved in your settings, so they survive restarts and updates.





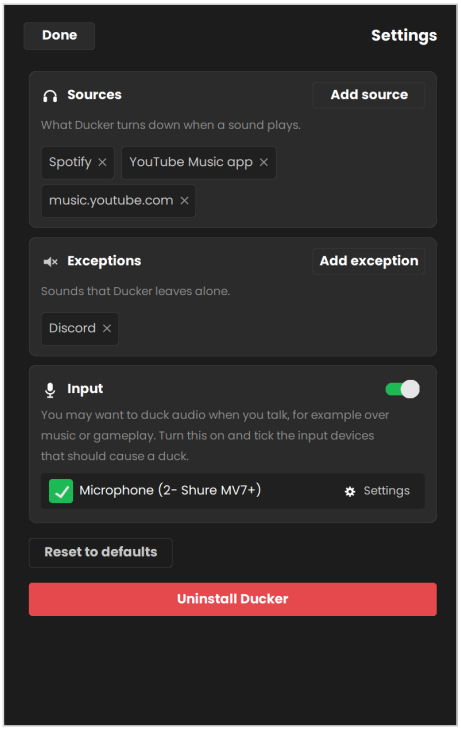
With Pause chosen there is one option, the delay.



Editing a mode. Delete mode is on the right.

Settings

Press **Settings** on the front page. Press **Done** at the top left to go back. Every change here saves itself as you make it.



Settings, with Input switched on.

Sources

Sources are what Ducker turns down. Spotify, Apple Music and YouTube Music are there from the start if they are on your PC. Each one is a small box with a cross. Press the cross to remove it.

Press **Add source** to add another. Type the name of an app, like VLC, and pick it from the list. You can also type a website address such as soundcloud.com. Ducker then treats any browser tab on that site as a source. Only apps that are on your PC are shown.

Exceptions

Exceptions are sounds Ducker leaves alone. They never make the source duck. Discord is there from the start, so a friend's message ping does not keep dipping your music. Add anything else the same way as a source, by app name or website address.

Input

Switch Input on and your microphone counts as a sound too. Talk and the source ducks. This is for voice chat over music, or recording a voice-over.

Once it is on, each microphone on your PC is listed with a tick box. Tick the ones that should count. Press the **Settings** cog next to a microphone for its sensitivity slider, which works the same way as Sound sensitivity. It starts at **Any noise**. Slide it right if breathing or keyboard noise sets it off.

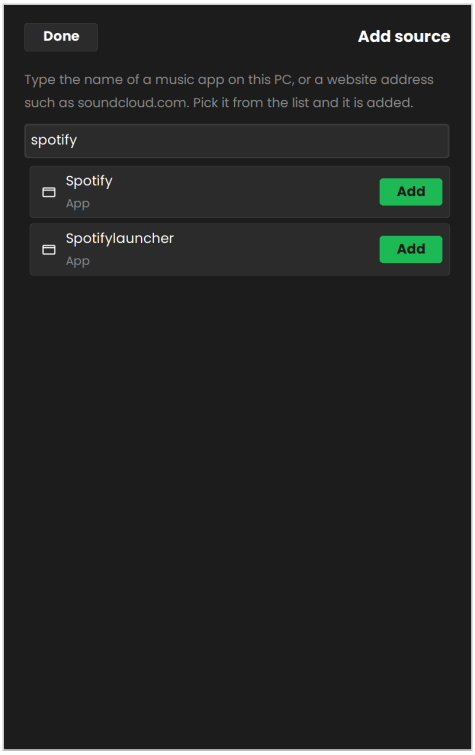
Ducker only reads how loud the microphone is. Nothing is recorded.

Reset to defaults

Puts Sources, Exceptions, Input and the chosen mode back to how they were when Ducker was first installed. Modes you made yourself are kept.

Uninstall Ducker

The red button at the bottom of Settings takes you to the uninstall page, covered later in this guide.



Adding a source. Type a name and press Add.



Adding an exception works the same way.

Apps and websites

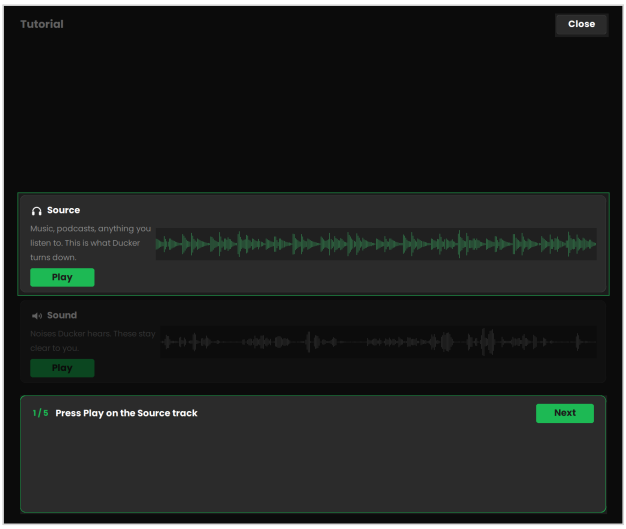
An **app** source is matched by its program, so Spotify is Spotify whatever it is playing. A **website** source is matched by the browser tab's title, so music.youtube.com only counts while a YouTube Music tab is open. Chrome, Edge, Firefox, Brave and Opera are all understood.

The same sound cannot be both a source and an exception. If you add something to one list, take it off the other.

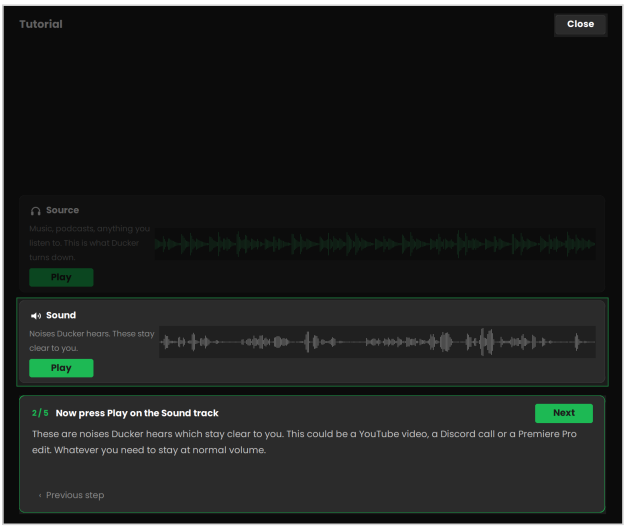
The Tutorial

Press **Tutorial** on the front page. The main window steps aside and a wider window opens with two tracks. **Source** is a short jazz loop, standing in for your music. **Sound** is a radio announcement, standing in for any other noise. A guide card at the bottom walks you through five steps, and the rest of the window dims so you can see what each step is about.

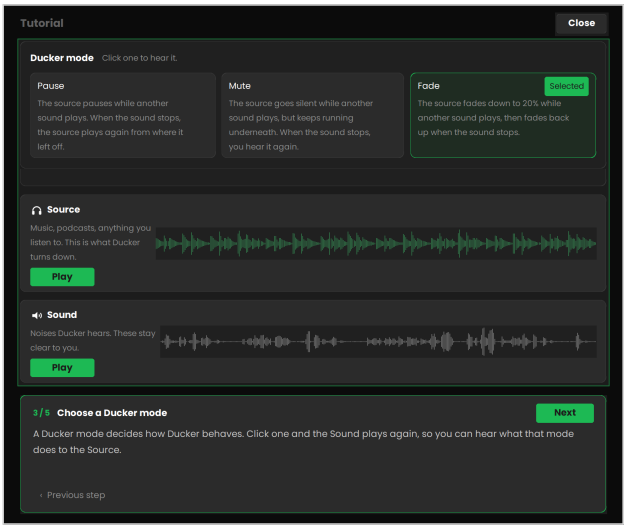
Nothing in the tutorial touches your real music. The two recordings are played by Ducker itself.



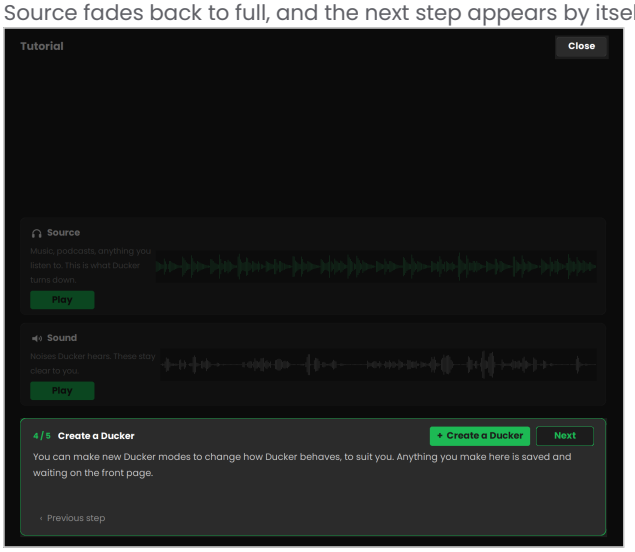
Step 1. Press Play on the Source track and the jazz loop starts. This is what Ducker turns down.



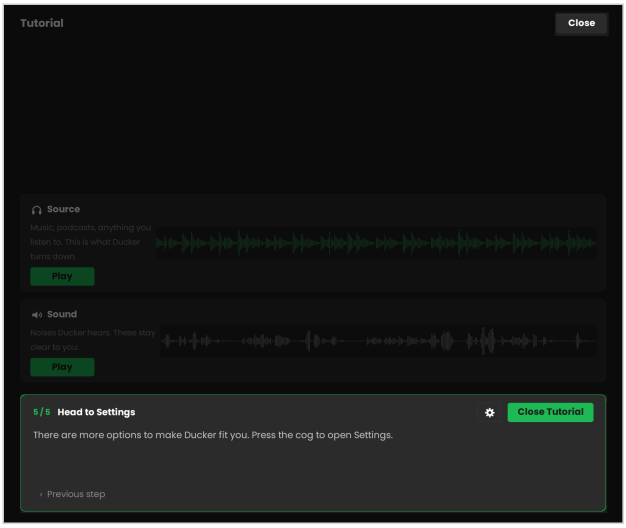
Step 2. Press Play on the Sound track. As the announcement plays, the Source drops to 15%. One second after it finishes, the Source fades back to full, and the next step appears by itself.



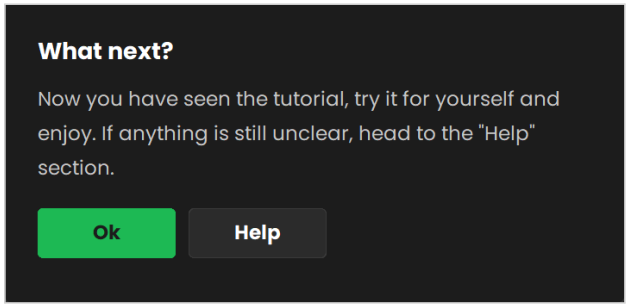
Step 3. The three modes appear at the top. Click one and the Sound plays again, so you hear exactly what Pause, Mute and Fade each do. The one you click is also chosen in the real app.



Step 4. Create a Ducker. The button in the card opens the real Create a Ducker window, and anything you save is waiting on the front page afterwards.



Step 5. Head to Settings. The cog next to Close Tutorial opens the real Settings page.



When you press Close Tutorial, or Close at any point, this box appears. Ok goes to the front page and Help goes to the help page.

Every step has a **Next** button on the right, so you can skip ahead, and from step 2 onwards a **Previous step** link at the bottom left of the card.

Four ways people use Ducker

The same app, set up four different ways. Each one takes a minute in Settings.

1. Editing a video with music in the background

You are cutting a video in Premiere Pro with Spotify on. Every time you scrub or play a clip, its audio plays, and that is a sound. Spotify ducks the moment the clip plays and comes back when you stop. You never reach for the pause button, and there is no eerie silence between edits either, because the music is simply quiet rather than off.

Set-up. Spotify is a source already. Choose **Fade**, or make your own mode with **Adjust volume to** around 10% so the music all but vanishes while you listen to your edit. If short clips make the music bounce up and down too much, raise **Fade speed out** to three or four seconds.

2. A film and a conversation

You are watching a film on your PC while on a voice call with a friend. When either of you talks, the film quietens so you can hear each other. When you both go quiet, the film comes back up.

Set-up. This time the film is the source and the voices are the sounds. Add the app you watch films in as a source, for example VLC, or a website such as netflix.com. Switch **Input** on and tick your microphone, so your own voice counts. Your friend's voice arrives through the call app, so make sure that app is not an exception. Discord is an exception by default, so remove it from that list if that is what you use. **Fade** to around 30% works well here, because you still want to follow the film.

3. Watching videos with music on

Music is on while you browse. You open a YouTube video, or a clip someone sent you, and the music drops out of the way on its own. When the video ends, the music fades back in. This is the set-up most people start with and it needs no changes at all.

Set-up. Your music app is a source. **Fade** is selected. Leave Active on. If you would rather the music stopped dead so you do not miss a track, pick **Pause** instead.

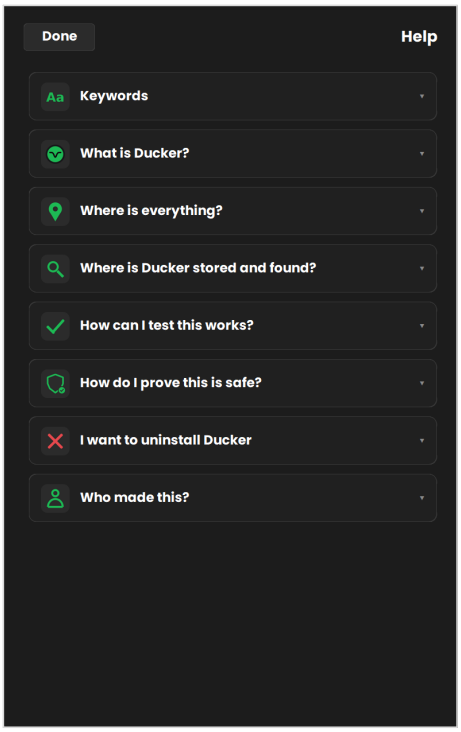
4. Alerts from software quietening the music

You want to hear every notification from, say, Teams or a build tool, without turning the music down for the whole day. Each alert ducks the music for a moment and it comes straight back.

Set-up. Make your own mode with **Fade speed in** at Instant, **Adjust volume to** at about 30%, and **Fade speed out** at one second, so a two-second ping gives a short, clean dip. If some apps' pings should not count, add those apps as exceptions. If tiny clicks are setting it off, move **Sound sensitivity** to the right so only proper alerts do.

Help, every question answered

The Help page in the app has eight questions. Click one and the answer opens underneath. The answers are repeated here so you have them on paper.



The Help page.

Keywords

Source is what you are listening to. Ducker turns the source down.

Sound is any other noise on your PC. A sound is what makes the source duck.

Duck is the dip. When a sound plays, the source gets quieter, pauses or mutes.

Ducker mode is what the duck does. Pause, Mute, Fade, or one you make yourself.

Exception is a sound that is left alone. It never makes the source duck.

Input is your microphone. Switch it on and talking makes the source duck too.

What is Ducker?

Ducker listens to the sounds on your PC, and focuses on the sounds that matter most to you, right when you need them. You tell it what your source is. When anything else makes a sound, Ducker turns the source down so you can hear the other thing clearly. When that sound stops, the source comes back. That is all it does.

Where is everything?

What	Where it is
Ducker mode	The front page. Choose Pause, Mute or Fade.
Sources and Exceptions	Settings.
Input	Settings, at the bottom.
Your own modes	The front page. Press Create a Ducker.
Turning it off	The Active switch at the top right, or the icon by the clock.

Where is Ducker stored and found?

Ducker lives in the system tray by the clock. Closing or minimising the window sends it there. Click the green circle to open it again, or right-click it for a menu. The program is installed in AppData\Local\Programs\Ducker, and the help page has buttons that open that folder and the settings folder for you.

How can I test this works?

Add a music source, like Spotify, and then play a song. As the song plays, play a video. You will hear Spotify automatically "duck" in volume. Ducker is customisable, so you can add any source, exception, input or setting you wish.

How do I prove this is safe?

Ducker does one thing. It moves the volume sliders you can see in Windows' own Volume Mixer. Here is everything it touches, and everything it does not.

What it does

- Reads how loud each app is, from the Volume Mixer.
- Moves the volume slider of your source apps, and moves it back.
- Reads window titles, so it can tell which website a browser tab is on.
- If you switch Input on, reads how loud your microphone is. Nothing is recorded.
- Keeps its settings in one small text file in your AppData folder.

What it never does

- Connect to the internet. There is no network code in it at all.
- Record audio, take screenshots, or read your files.
- Run as administrator, or change anything outside its own folder.
- Start anything you did not ask for. It only runs itself at sign-in, and you can switch that off.

To check for yourself, open Task Manager and watch Ducker. It uses almost no processor time and has no network activity. You can upload Ducker.exe to VirusTotal, which scans it with seventy security products, or right-click the file and choose Scan with Microsoft Defender.

I want to uninstall Ducker

Ducker is safe to remove at any time. It only adjusts volume, the same sliders you can move yourself in the Volume Mixer, so uninstalling it puts everything back exactly as it was. Press the red button on that help section or at the bottom of Settings, or open Ducker - Uninstall from the Start Menu. The next page covers it.

Who made this?

Hello, I'm Jacob Hammersley, a creative strategist and media producer. I created Ducker as I found music was necessary to the background of my creative life... until it got in the way!

When creating content, I'd have to faff with opening the relevant music apps, stopping it, edit videos, and then hearing the eerie silence of no music when I was done. This isn't system-breaking, but it is enough to disrupt my creative flow. I wanted something that could do this seamlessly so I can get on with what I wanted to, and music could continue being the background of my creativity!

After realising this could be useful beyond video editing... I made Ducker.

Uninstalling Ducker

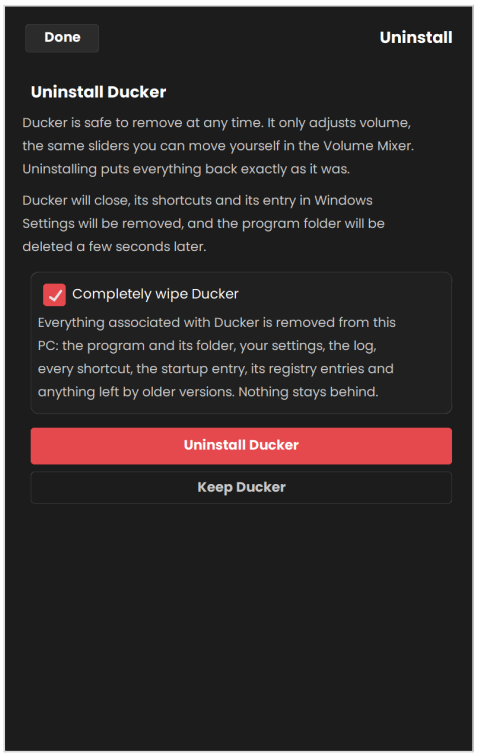
There are two ways and they do the same thing. Nothing is left behind either way.

From inside Ducker

Press **Uninstall Ducker** at the bottom of Settings, or in the Help page. The page on the right explains what will happen.

Completely wipe Ducker is ticked by default. With it ticked, everything associated with Ducker is removed from the PC. The program and its folder, your settings, the log, every shortcut, the startup entry, its registry entries, and anything left by older versions. Untick it to keep your settings for a future reinstall.

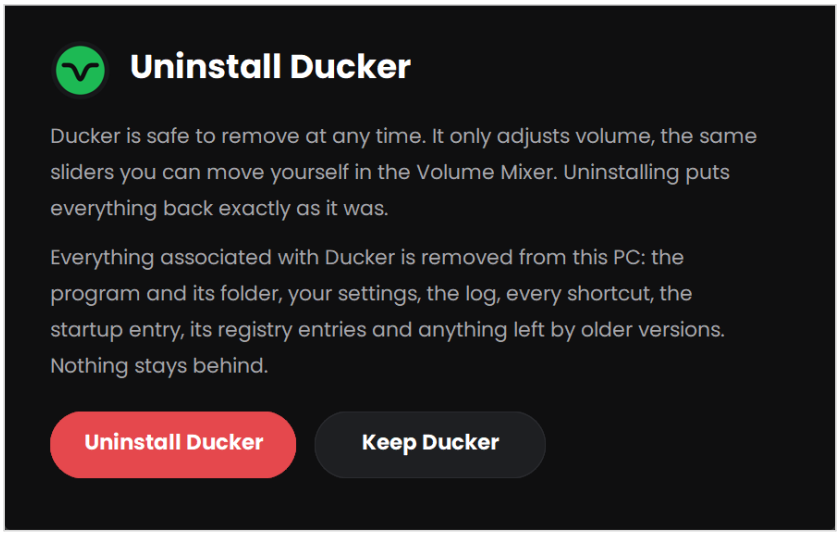
Press the red **Uninstall Ducker** button. Ducker closes and removes itself, and its folder is deleted a few seconds later. **Keep Ducker** takes you back to where you were.



The uninstall page inside the app.

From the Start Menu or Windows Settings

Open **Ducker - Uninstall** from the Start Menu, or find Ducker in Windows Settings under Installed apps and press Uninstall. A single window appears with the same wording. Press the red button and everything is removed. When it is done, Windows shows a message saying "Ducker is uninstalled".



Ducker - Uninstall, from the Start Menu.

Quick answers

If this happens	Try this
Nothing ducks	Check the Active switch is on. Check your music app is listed under Sources in Settings. If the sound that should cause the duck comes from an app in Exceptions, remove it from that list. If the mode is one you made, check Sound sensitivity is not set too far to the right.
The music keeps dipping for no reason	Something quiet is counting as a sound. Make your own mode and move Sound sensitivity to the right, or add the app that is causing it as an exception.
The music is stuck quiet	Right-click the tray icon and choose Put everything back to full volume. This also happens by itself the next time Ducker starts.
A website is not counted as a source	Websites are matched by the tab's title, so the tab has to be open in a normal browser window. Add the address exactly, for example music.youtube.com.
I closed the window and Ducker has gone	It has not. It is in the tray by the clock. Press the small ^ arrow if the icon is hidden.
I want it to stop starting with Windows	Reinstall with the start-up box unticked, or delete the Ducker shortcut from the Startup folder in the Start Menu.
Windows warned me when installing	That is SmartScreen, which warns about any program it has not seen many times. Click More info, then Run anyway.
Something went wrong and I want to report it	Ducker keeps a plain text log at AppData\Roaming\Ducker\ducker.log. The Help page has a button that opens that folder.

The settings file

Everything you choose is kept in one small text file, settings.json, in AppData\Roaming\Ducker. Reinstalling or updating Ducker keeps it. Uninstalling with Completely wipe Ducker ticked deletes it.

Keyboard

Escape on the front page sends Ducker to the tray. On any other page it goes back to the front page. In the Add source box, **Enter** adds the first result in the list.